incomes stagnant. Nearly 61 per cent of those polled believe their household income will either stay the same or worsen, with only 29 per cent expecting an improvement. Notably, 41 per cent of the Scheduled Tribe (ST) respondents—the highest among all caste groups—expect an increase in their household income over the next six months.

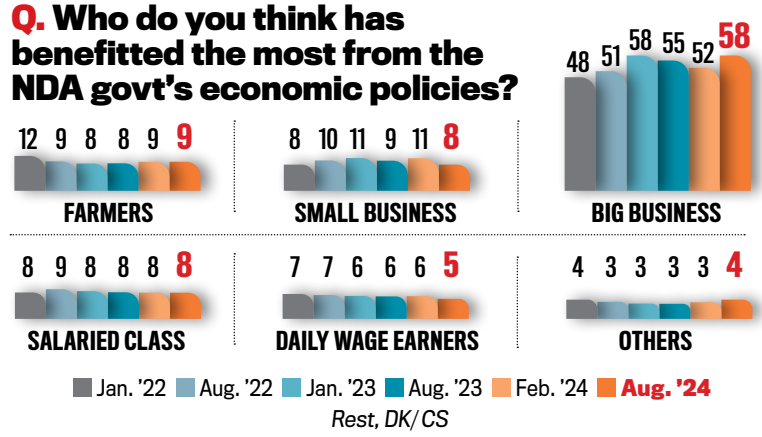
RUNAWAY EXPENSES

Rising prices have been a significant bugbear for the government. In June, food inflation surged to 9.4 per cent due to costlier vegetables, cereals, milk and fruits, before cooling to 5.4 per cent in July. Vegetable inflation, which stayed in double digits for eight months until June, has been a major worry, along with the persistent high prices of foodgrains. However, retail inflation fell to 3.5 per cent in July, marking its lowest point in over five years. Announcing its monetary policy on August 8, the Reserve Bank of India kept the key repo rate, or the rate at which it lends to banks, unchanged to rein in prices, noting that headline inflation had moderated, but unevenly. High prices are inevitably straining the common man's finances. A significant 63 per cent of the MOTN respondents report that managing their current expenses has become difficult, while another 28 per cent feel their expenses have risen but are still manageable. Only 7 per cent say their expenses have decreased.

THE JOBS QUESTION

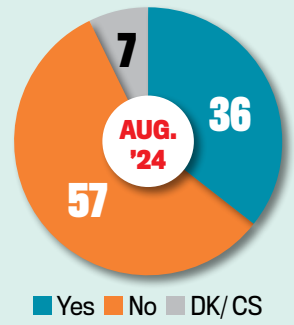
Employment generation is another key source of worry. In 2022-23, the unemployment rate among the 15-29 age group stood at 10 per cent. Central government data shows that India's workforce numbered nearly 565 million that year, with over 45 per cent employed in agriculture, 11.4 per cent in manufacturing, 28.9 per cent in services and 13 per cent in construction. The reliance on agriculture for nearly half of the population's employment, particularly among women,

Q. Who do you think has benefitted the most from the NDA govt's economic policies?



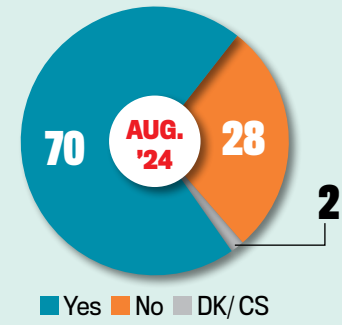
Most respondents feel that big business is the biggest beneficiary of the Modi government's economic policies

Q. Do you agree with the central government's claim that 80 million jobs have been created in the last three years?



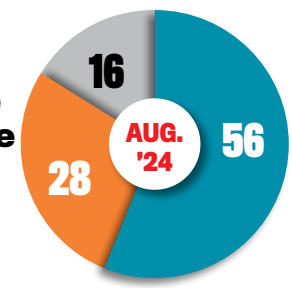
Many doubt the govt's claim of having created such a large number of jobs

Q. Will you opt for a government job even if it offers 25-30 lesser salary than a private job you have secured or likely to secure?



Government jobs are highly sought after for a significant number of people

Q. Should the government be disinvesting the loss-making PSUs?



Most believe the government should exit unprofitable PSUs

All figures in % and rounded off

27% of the respondents with higher education rate the NDA government's handling of the economy as very poor

41% of the ST respondents, the highest among all caste groups, expect their household income to improve in the next six months